

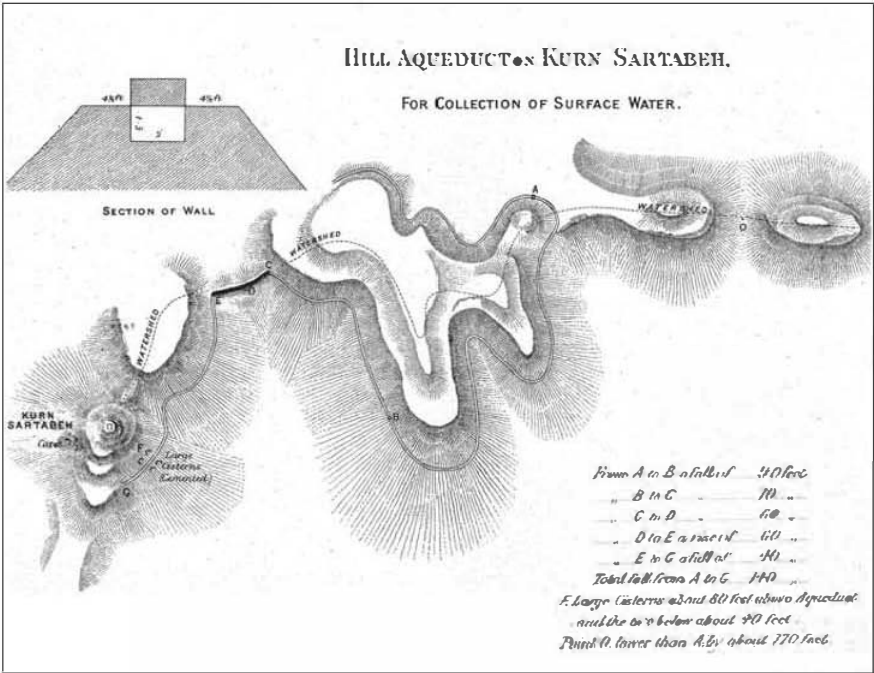
Site 171: 19-16/36/1

THE SARTABA WATER SYSTEM

Israel grid: 193/166 (central)	Soil type: stony-desert
UTM grid: 731/553 (central)	Soil quality: 3
Elevation: about 300 m a.s.l., (average)	Cultivation: none
Name: functional	Cisterns: those of the Sartaba fortress
Site type: water collecting system	Water source: at the site
Area: about 700 dunams (70 ha) – drainage basin	Road: Wadi Jeruzaliyeh (C43), near by the system
Topography: mountainous plateau	Visits: 1996. 2001 and many repeated visits; 150 sherds
Rock type: Avdat Group	

A sophisticated system for catching and collecting rain water, spread over large area west of the Sartaba fortress. The system includes aqueducts at various elevations, a siphon across a low valley, and cisterns.

The system was first investigated by the British Survey (March and April 1874) with elevations, calculations and a drawing: “On the ridge west of the tell



323. Plan of the Sartaba water system as measured and drawn by the British Survey in 1874 (Conder and Kitchener 1882: facing p. 397).

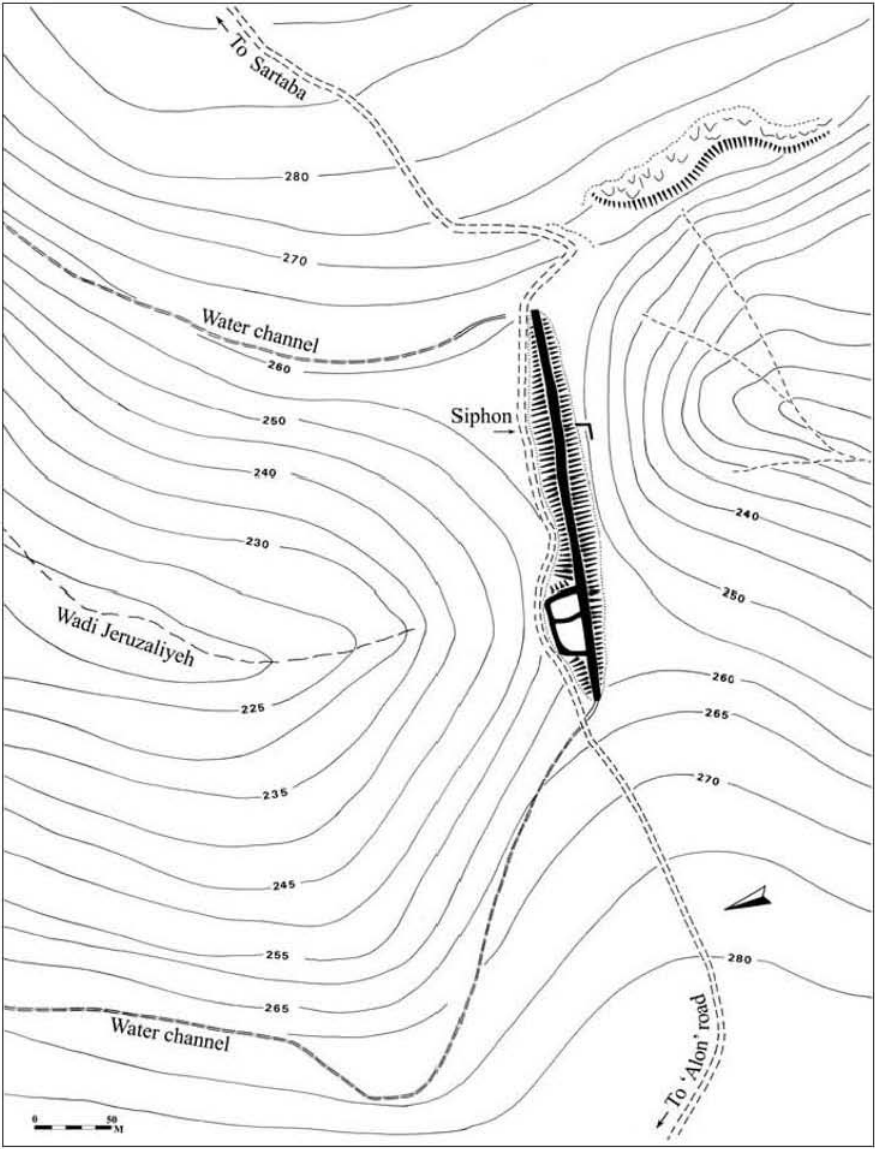
there is a well. About half mile further west there is a low saddle, which has been artificially banked across; and a long narrow wall runs on the bank, with remains of a channel 1 foot 3 inches deep and 2 feet wide with covering blocks of stones, which were probably 8 or 10 feet long. This aqueduct was traced all round the north side of the Kurn block of hill, and evidently collected surface drainage, as the level prevents the supposition of its connection with any neighbouring spring or well of water.

The total length is about 2.5 miles, but the starting-point is only $\frac{3}{4}$ mile



324. Plan of the Sartaba water system, published by Amit, 1984.

west of the tell. The watershed north of Ras Kaneitrah is 17● feet lower than the aqueduct on that side, and the line is plainly seen running round the hill, with a fall of 1●● feet in about 1.5 miles, measuring to the bank across the saddle, where the channel dips in crossing, the centre being about 5● or 6● feet lower than the ends. From the saddle the line runs directly east on the north side of the hill, with a fall of 4● feet in a mile. It supplies large cemented cave-



325. Plan of a part of the lower aqueduct and the Hellenistic siphon of the Sartaba water system, 2001.

cisterns about 35● feet or more below the top of the tell, and it runs past them to terraces which seem artificial, and many have supported gardens irrigated by the channel. In places the channel is built of large rudely hewn blocks. The well or cistern mentioned above, on the plateau west of the tell, may perhaps have been connected with the aqueduct, being at rather higher level." (Conder and Kitchen 1882: 397-398).

The water system was also investigated by David Amit (1984).

In June 2001 we drew the siphon which transfers the water from west to east across the saddle between the drainage systems of Wadi Jeruzaliyah (north) and Wadi 'Amrah (south). The length of the siphon is about 25● m. It includes a built channel, measuring 6●×6● cm, covered by stone slabs. The beginning section of the channel in the western side was fully exposed. The width of the built base on and within which the aqueduct passes is about 2 m. This base is built as a platform of cut stones in several distinct phases, perhaps repairs. There may have been several channels, but this cannot be proven without excavation.

The stone base and duct rest on an elevated foundation, whose maximum width at the bottom is about 4● m. The foundation was built of stones collected in the vicinity, and its maximum height at the centre of the saddle is about 6 m. Alongside and attached to the western side of the siphon is an expansion 2● m long and 7 m wide, forming a pool or structure, and divided by an internal wall into two unequal parts. The siphon duct links directly to the water collecting

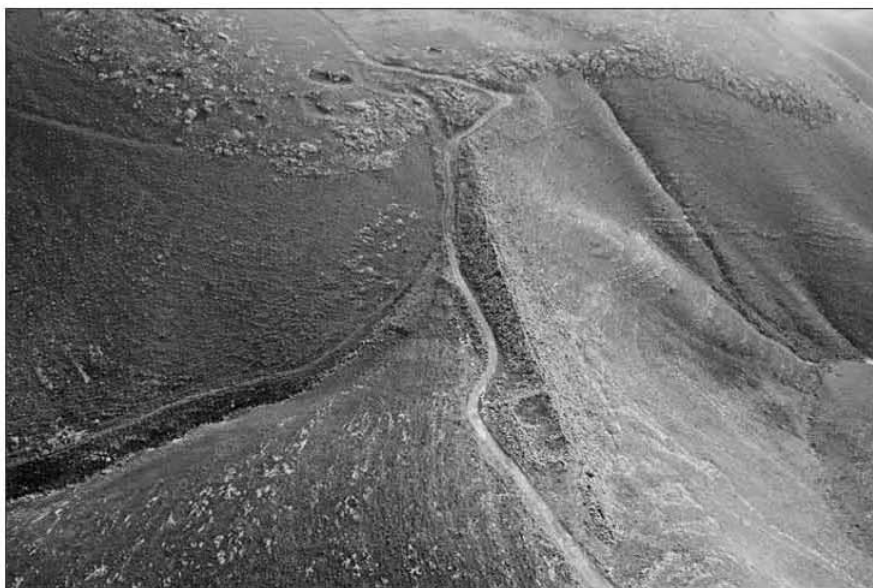


326. The Sartaba siphon, view to the east, 1993. In the foreground is the entry point of the aqueduct into the siphon (M. Einav).

channel in the west, which is clearly visible on the Quneitra extension. On the eastern side this connection was cut by a new unpaved road ascending to the Sartaba.

Many sherds were found in the area of the siphon and channel.

Pottery: Hellenistic – 70%; Early Roman – 30%.



327. Aerial view of the Sartaba siphon, view to the east, 2013 (A. Solomon).



328. One of the Sartaba cisterns, 1997 (M. Einav).

Site 172: 19-16/36/2

LOWER SARTABA

Israel grid: 1934/1668 (central)	Rock type: Avdat Group
UTM grid: 7320/5537 (central)	Soil type: stony-desert
Elevation: 310 m a.s.l., 0 m a.s.a.	Soil quality: 4
Name: nearest place	Cultivation: none
Site type: stone quarries and settlement	Cisterns: 4
Area: about 15 dunams (1.5 ha)	Water source: 'Ein el-Mana (176), 2 km distant
Topography: saddle surrounded by slopes	Road: roads C43-46, next to the site
	Visit: April 2001; 55 sherds

Quarries, settlement and supply base at the foot south-west of the Alexandrion fortress, in the broad saddle close to the west side of the aqueduct.

South-west of the fortress cone is a large area, about 600×300 m, which slopes down south to the cliffs above the siphon. Over this surface are various workings, all apparently linked to the fortress of Alexandrion, its foundation and maintenance:

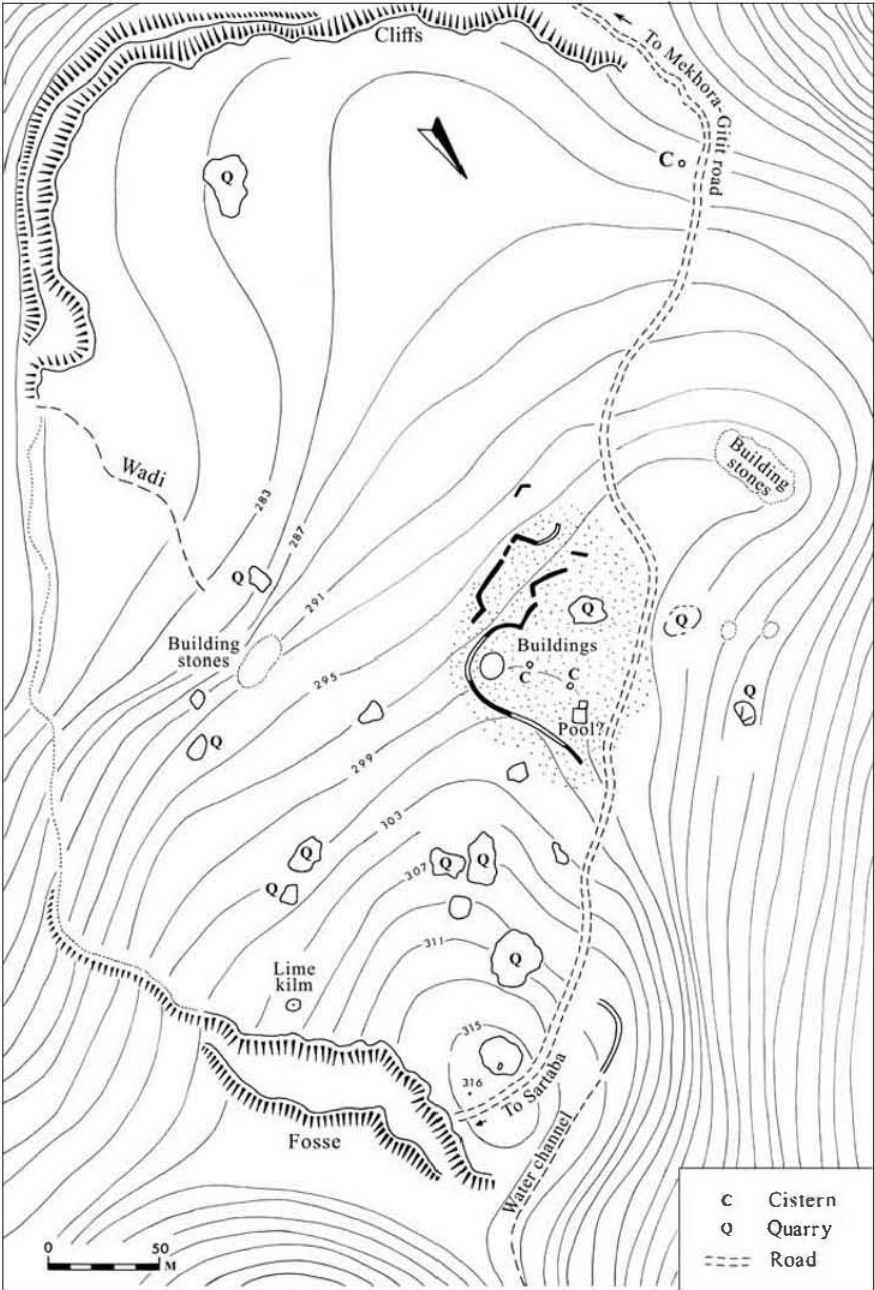
A. Quarries: in at least 50 locations over the surface of the saddle are quarrying marks in the rock, the source of building stones for the fortress. This area shows the following methods of quarrying:

A.1. Irregular large rock-hewn recesses, mostly oval or round, from 5 to 30 m across. Their average depth is about 1 m, and some are 2 m deep. These pits can be identified as remains of quarrying by their straight-cut edges, and it is apparent that stones were taken out from them. These recesses are spread all over the saddle, but their main concentration is in the western part, close to the Sartaba cliffs and the siphon area.

A.2. Grooves: cut into rock surfaces, into which wooden wedges were jammed and then wetted to expand and crack the rock. There are a few of these, mainly on the northern slope.

A.3. The moat: the western moat of the fortress, separating the Sartaba cone and the western saddle, is also a large quarry. It is about 30 m wide and about 10 m deep. Found in it were large building stones, some apparently rolled down from the fortress.

B. 'A quarrymen's village': in the northern part of the saddle, close to the new unpaved road and the aqueduct, is a small settlement, about 3 dunams (3000 sq. m) in area, containing 20 structures or remains of structures. The structures are poorly preserved, making it difficult to discern their plans without excavation. At the centre of the settlement are cisterns and a plastered pool. In our



329. Plan of Lower Sartaba, 2001.

opinion, the settlement served as a centre for the quarry workers and fortress builders, and was apparently abandoned once the fortress was finished; although it may have remained in use longer as a supply base. Another cistern is 100 m north-west of the settlement, but it is difficult to determine whether was related to the site.

C. The aqueduct: passes along the northern side of the saddle (for details see Site 171). Here it appears as a dug and built channel about 1 m wide. In most places the duct is ruined or blocked with silt, but it is still possible to follow its route. In certain places two phases (or two ducts) can be seen, one above the other.

Meshel (1989: 297) noticed the remains on the western plateau, describing it thus: "Over the area...are found relatively many remains, obviously, part of them recent: recesses and pits for drainage of local surface water, various lines of walls, pens for herds, etc. For example...south of the road we exposed, while searching for the dike, a plastered installation, *miqveh*-like (?), lines of walls, heaps of stones, a long line of a pen or terrace, and other finds. Here was apparently the main assembly area for the army besieging the fortress, and perhaps also the king's guard's encampment place when the king stayed in the fortress. At a high point on the western side of the plateau are, in our opinion, vague remains of an enclosure, possibly connected to our subject. However, the information available to us at this stage is insufficient to state anything firm."

Meshel's opinion that the platform served as the assembly area for every army intending to besiege the place is acceptable. Only here is a flat surface



330. Lower Sartaba (on the plateau west of Alexandrion Fortress), viewed to the east from the siphon, 1996 (M. Einav).

large enough for the purpose, with at least two roads leading to it, which then ascend to the fortress from this direction.

Pottery: Hellenistic – 80%; Early and Late Roman – 15%; Middle Ages – 5%.

Flint: 15 items, see Appendix A.

Additional surveys: none.

Additional Bibliography: Conder and Kitchener 1882: 397–398.



Site 173: 19-16/37/1

SARTABA FORTRESS

Israel grid: 1937/1670 (central)

UTM grid: 7323/5539 (central)

Elevation: 377 m a.s.l., 100 m a.s.a.

Name: ancient and on map

Site type: Fortress

Topography: high cone

Rock type: Avdat Group

Soil type: stony-desert

Soil quality: 2

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: 14

Water source: see site 171 above

Road: roads C43–46, next to the site

Visits: First visit 1993 and numerous repeated visits; 850 sherds

A fortress on a prominent topographical cone in the eastern part of the Sartaba plateau. The fortress is a complex compound, whose components are: 1. the Sartaba fortress; 2. the approach roads; 3. the water system (Site 171); 4. Lower Sartaba (the quarries and quarrymen's village – Site 172); and 5. the siege works (Site 165). Components 1 and 2 are discussed below; the others have been dealt with under their site numbers.

1. Alexandrion Fortress: the discussion comprises: A) description; B) history; C) travellers' descriptions and various other sources; D) excavations; E) newly raised aspects.

A) Description: Structures with various parts at the top of the Sartaba cone and its eastern slope, all belonging to the fortress complex. The main components are:

A.1. The summit: an elongated irregular surface, measuring about 95×40 m, with steep slopes down from it in all directions. It is divided into the southern area, in which a central structure stood, and the northern area, descending moderately from south to north. The summit is encircled by a wall, parts of which were found to the north-east and south-west of the summit. The surviving part of the enclosure wall is two stones wide, which is about 1 m, but it

seems originally to have been thicker. In the north-eastern part of the summit the wall seems to have been double, with a 5 m gap between the walls. The lower wall of the two was not actually discovered, and its supposed existence is deduced from the dyke it formed on the slope.

A.2. The northern surface of the summit: an oval area sloping north strewn with building stones. In its north-eastern part are the remains of the enclosure wall with a tower (?) or a structure at the higher end, commanding the slope. The stones from tower collapse lie in the higher part of the northern surface. Five large circular robbing pits were dug in the northern area. Three of them are grouped by the entrance in the central upper part of that area. The largest pit is about 9 m in diameter and about 1.5 m deep. A disorganized excavation is clearly visible, aimed, in our opinion, at finding significant structures. The dig exposed a thick wall built of ashlar, which was an element in the structures on the northern slope, and perhaps the entrance structure. Close by and east of the large pit are two pits, 6 and 5 m in diameter. They are about 1.5 m deep, and also contain building remains. A smaller pit is by the western wall, south of the presumed entrance, and there is another pit at the north of the area next to a robbing trench.

The robbing pits, like the excavation south-west of the southern structure on the summit, have not been mentioned in any scientific account. The British Survey (Conder and Kitchener 1882: 397) mentions them; from which we deduce that these are robbing digs conducted on the Sartaba summit by a European traveller in the first half of the 19th century. At that time the 'custom' of unregulated robbing excavations was common in various places, triggered by the discoveries in Egypt: however, there are other possibilities.

A.3. The southern structure on the summit: a rather small, 30×20 m, horizontally stepped structure. Three steps were exposed, the northern one about 20 m wide and the southern one about 6 m wide. They appear in plans by Abel (1913: Ill. 7) and Bar-Adon (1972: site 5). The only part of the structure exposed is the south-western edge, where a wall was discovered, and currently stands 2–3 m high (10 courses of large cut stones). Some of the stones have drafted margins and a boss; others are smooth ashlar, and the rest were originally bossed, but smoothed later. The construction is headers and stretchers, but in this also there is no uniformity.

The building has been badly damaged by an earthquake, and some of the walls are tilted sideways or downwards. The lack of uniformity in the cutting of the stones and in the laying of the headers and stretchers (Abel 1913: 229–230; Moulton 1936: 18) suggested to researchers that the wall is later than the Herodian era; but this is as yet unsubstantiated. Close to the south-western wall is a large excavation which exposed some of the walls and the southern part of the structure. From the look of the excavation it appears that it was not

scientific but a robbing dig. An excavation on the eastern side is shallower. It is not obvious who excavated and when: in a note Tsafrir and Magen (1984: 27) claimed that it originated in the first half of the 20th century; however, the British Survey (Conder and Kitchener 1882: 397) shows that it already existed in 1872. There is no doubt that this excavation took place after the earthquake which destroyed the building, because the fallen stones were taken out of the dig. The foundation trench of the structure and its root in the bedrock were exposed during this excavation. The measurements of the structure taken by various researchers at different times vary slightly, but its horizontally stepped construction is absolutely clear.

The volume of the collapse stones covering the remains of the southern structure indicates a very tall building, towering at least 10 m above the present level. Judging by the construction method and number of stones scattered over the slope, it is apparent that the southern structure served as sort of observation fort (or for another purpose) prominent above the summit, while the main area of the palace was on the eastern slope.

A.4. The eastern slope: the entire upper part of the eastern slope was apparently built up. Nowadays it is covered by a collapse heap of large stones, originating from the upper structure and structures on the slope. About 50 m below the upper tip of the cone were a large structure, excavated by Tsafrir's expedition (below – D), and a Herodian peristyle with heart-shaped columns.

A.5. The approach roads to the upper structure have not been preserved,



331. Aerial view of The Sartaba Fortress, view to the west, 1997. Note the cisterns and the setting of the site (M. Einav).

but it is apparent that stairs ascended to it from north and south. It could be surmised that such a system, or possibly a constructed pathway, ascended from north-west, more or less where the present path is. This is the most convenient approach from the western saddle and the moat. In the south, remains of stairs have been preserved; Meshel (1970: 105) reports other stairs coming from the Wadi Qurein road (C45).

B. History: the fortress was founded during the Hellenistic period, but there is no substantiated information as who was the founder. The name of the place is derived from the name of the wife of Alexander Jannaeus (103–76 BCE), Shlomzion (Salome) Alexandra (76–67 BCE). Its history can be divided into two: 1. A refuge fortress during the Hasmonean period; 2. A family prison and burial place in Herod's time.

B.1. The refuge fortress: The first mention appears in Ant. XIII, xvi: 3, while discussing Alexandra's deeds: "But still they themselves were to blame for their misfortunes, in allowing a woman to reign who madly desired it in her unreasonable love for power, and when her sons were in the prime of life. And so the Queen, not knowing what to do consistent with her dignity, entrusted to them the guarding of the fortresses with the exception of Hyrcania, Alexandreion and Machaerus, where her most valuable possessions were."

A slightly later piece of information (concerning the year 63 BCE) appears in War I, vi: 5 (and likewise in Ant. XIV, iii: 4): "Indignant at this behaviour, and yielding to the urgent entreaties of Hyrcanus and his friends, Pompey started



332. The southern projection of the horizontally stepped structure at the Sartaba Fortress, view to the north, 1996 (S. Hashman).

in pursuit of Aristobulus, with the Roman forces and a large contingent of Syrian auxiliaries. Passing Pella and Scythopolis, he reached Coreae, at which point a traveller ascending through the interior enters the territory of Judaea. There he heard that Aristobulus had taken refuge in Alexandreion, one of the lavishly equipped fortresses, situated on a high mountain, and sent orders to him to come down."

Further on there are notes regarding the negotiations between Aristobulus and Pompey, while Aristobulus alternately goes up and down the fortress (Ant. XIV, iii: 4).

Alexander, son of Aristobulus, fortified Alexandrion's walls (although there is no information of the walls having been damaged before then): "But some time later, while Alexander, the son of Aristobulus, was overrunning Judaea, Gabinius came to Syria from Rome as governor, and after achieving many other things of note, also marched against Alexander... (who) then went round the country and armed many of the Jews, and soon collected ten thousand heavily-armed soldiers and fifteen hundred horse, and fortified the strongholds of Alexandreion near Coreae and Machaerus near the mountains of Arabia. Gabinius therefore went out against him..." (Ant. XIV, v: 2; and likewise in War I, viii: 2)

The next piece of information deals with the war waged by Gabinius, the Roman commissioner left by Pompey (about 57 BCE), against Alexander: "With the remnant of his army he fled to Alexandreion. Gabinius, following him thither, found many of his men camping outside the walls. Before attacking them, he endeavoured, by promise of pardon for past offences, to bring them over to his side; but, on their proudly refusing all terms, he killed a large number of them and confined the remainder in the fortress... Leaving the reduction of the fort to his troops, Gabinius made a parade of the country, restoring order in the cities which had escaped devastation, and rebuilding those he found in ruins...After supervising these arrangements, Gabinius returned to Alexandreion and pressed the siege so vigorously that Alexander, despairing of success, sent him a herald with a petition for pardon for his offences and an offer to surrender the fortresses of Hyrcania and Machaerus, still in his possession; subsequently he gave up Alexandreion as well. All these places Gabinius demolished, to prevent their serving as a base of operations for another war. He was instigated to take this step by Alexander's mother, who had come to propitiate him, in her concern for her husband and remaining children, then prisoners in Rome." (War I, viii: 3-5; and likewise in Ant. XIV, v: 3-4).

Alexander, who later fled from Rome "...began by seizing Alexandreion and attempting to restore the fortifications; but on hearing that Gabinius had dispatched an army against him... he retreated toward Machaerus." (War I, viii:

6; and likewise in Ant. XIV, vi: 1)

B.2. Imprisonment and burial place during Herod's reign: the second chapter in the history of the fortress is connected to Herod I 'The Great' (37 BCE – 4 CE), who rebuilt the fortress as part of the inheritance struggle between himself and Antigonus: "He (Herod) instructed Pheroras, his youngest brother... to fortify Alexandreion." (War I, xvi: 3; and likewise in Ant. XIV, xv: 4). This information is dated to 39/38 BCE.

In 30/29 BCE, when the strife within the House of Herod escalated, resulting from the envy of the daughters of the Hasmonean family in Edom who rose to prominence, the king imprisoned his wife Miriam and her mother in the fortress: "As for his wife Mariamme – since it was impossible for her to live in the same place because of the quarrel between her and his mother and sister - he placed her in Alexandreion with her mother Alexandra, leaving in charge there his steward Joseph and Soemus the Ituraean... And they, too, were given instructions that if they learned that anything bad had happened to him, they were to dispose of both women at once..." (Ant. XV, vi: 5).

When Marcus Agrippa visited the land (15 BCE) Herod hosted him: "...in the fortresses which he had built at great expense, Alexandreion, Herodion and Hyrcania." (Ant. XVI, ii: 1).

The last chapter in the history of Herod's fortress is linked to one of the most tragic events in the dynasty's history: Herod's murder of his sons by Miriam – Alexander and Aristobulus. The event begins with a faked letter of accusation from Alexander to the commander of Alexandrion, who was tortured but refused to give false evidence (War I, xxvi: 3; Ant. XVI, x: 4). This event ended when: "...Alexander and Aristobulus were taken to Sebaste and at the command of their father were killed by strangling. During the night their bodies were laid away in Alexandreion, where their maternal grandfathers and most of their ancestors were buried." (Ant. XVI, xi: 7).

Thus, during Herod's reign, the fortress served as a family prison, a guest house and a magnificent necropolis for the Hasmonean family.

The latest information (in the Mishnah, 3rd century CE) mentions the Sartaba as a station for lighting beacons between Jerusalem and the Babylonian diaspora, notifying the sighting of the New Moon – *Rosh-Hodesh*: "And from where did they light the flares? From the Mount of Olives to Sarteba, and from Sarteba to Agrippina, and from Agrippina to Havan, and from Havan to Bet Biltin; and from Bet Biltin they did not move, but he waved to and fro and he raised and lowered until he would see the whole Diaspora before him like a mass of fire." (Rosh Hashanah, chapter 2, Mishnah 4 [Kehati 1990: 25]). The next stations were across the Jordan and on to Babylon. In the source quoted above the name Sartaba and not Alexandrion appears for the first time.

A puzzling item of information appears in the *Midrash Vayisau*, in its

original form probably dated not later than the Bar-Kokhba War (Schmitt 1983: 48; Strack and Stemberger 1991: 360-361), concerning the city of Zarethan (mentioned in Josh 3, 16; 1 Kgs 4, 12; 7, 46): "On the second day they went to Sarethan and here too they had a great war with them (the Canaanites). (It was) a high city on a high mound... and it was impossible to be defeated." (Yalkut Shim'oni, Bereshit, Vayishlakh XIII, p. LXII).

C. Travellers' descriptions and various other sources: from the many informative descriptions of the fortress, we have chosen those from the 19th and the beginning of the 20th century. Due to their abundance, only those containing a fresh contribution to the description and understanding of the place are included. Because of the poor outer state of preservation of the remains and the lack of excavation, there are not many of these: most of the visitors focus on the historical aspects, which will not be repeated.

Robinson (1970, III: 293-294) mentions the fortress, claiming to have visited it, but it seems be no substance to this. On May 11th 1857 he observed eastward from the village of Duma, writing the following: "The long, high, rocky ridge of the Surtabeh was over against us on the left...on its highest part is the horn not unlike that of a rhinoceros in form. Beyond this is a large shoulder; and then a low rocky ridge reaching almost down to the Jordan (to the *Ghor*, A. Z.)... The people here and elsewhere spoke of ruins somewhere on Surtabeh, and a reservoir for water; to which there was formerly an aqueduct from Nabulus! I examined the summit long and carefully with one of Plossl's *Feldstecher*; but

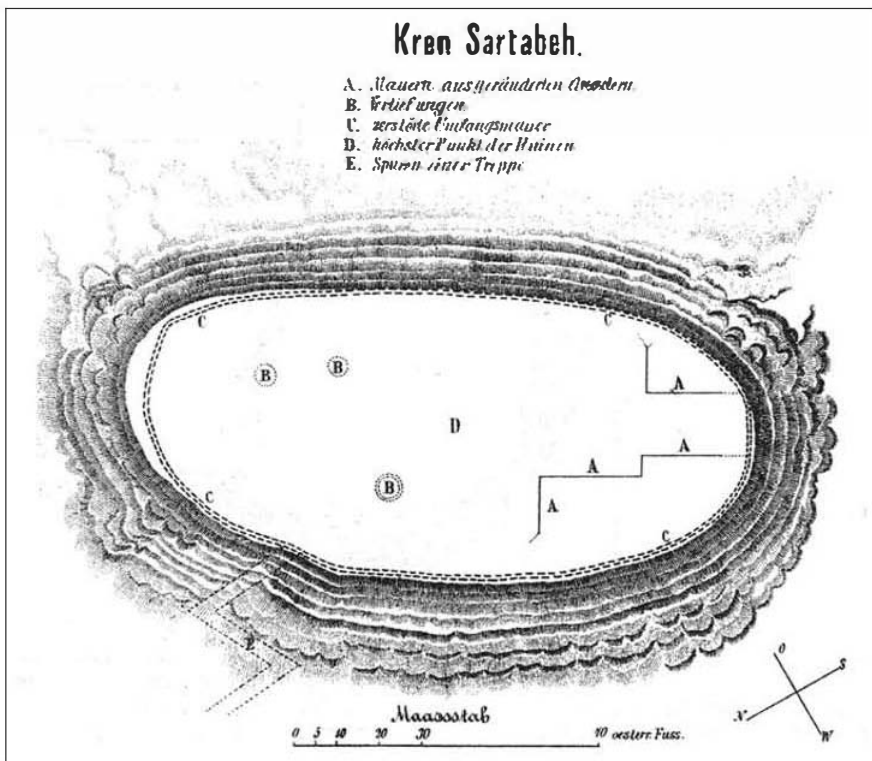


333. Aerial view of the Sartaba Fortress, view to the east, 2013 (A. Solomon).

could discover no appearance of ruins; more especially not upon the horn. The distance on an air line could hardly have been more than two or two and a half miles."

On 5 March 1874 Clermont-Ganneau (1874: 173-178) wrote a long letter that deals clearly with the meaning of the name Sartaba, but does not mention a visit to the place.

On 21 March 1874 the member of the British Survey, Colonel Tyrwhitt Drake (1874: 189-190) reports: "Kurn Sartabeh: Between this camp at Wady Fusail and our present one (Wadi Far'ah) is a very remarkable conical hill called Kurn Sartabeh, or Horn of Sartabeh, who, according to the Arabs, was an ancient king who built the castle there. He is by some called Sabartalah. This horn or peak is a very prominent point, and visible from Hermon and from Moab, as well as from many places on both the eastern and the western hills. It rises about 1,500 feet above sea level, and consequently is 2,500 feet higher than the Jordan at this part of its course. An old path zigzags up a ridge from the south, and by this we rode up. To the west of the peak a ruined aqueduct...A very steep ascent of 270 feet from this western ditch brought us to the top, where



334. Sartaba Fortress, the summit plan by Zschokke (1866).

are solid masses of masonry with drafted stones having irregular rustic bosses, and varying in length from two to three and a half feet by two feet in height... The stones employed in the construction (of the central construction – namely the fortress) are hard marbly limestone, seemingly dolomite, and very heavy. The labour of bringing them up to such a position must have been very great, as the nearest point from which they could have been hewn is nearly a mile distant.”

On 25 April 1874 Guérin (1969: 245) visited the place and gave a detailed report. He describes the peak of the fortress as being encircled by a wall built of huge stones, with flattened faces or ashlar, some of which are laid cross-wise and some lengthwise. Those whose contacting surfaces are flawless are not cemented; between those which are less perfectly matched all cracks are filled with small stone splinters stuck with clay which served as cement. He reports that from this fortress only the southern part is still standing; it ends with a square tower encircled by a moat. From this tower, with some of its lower courses still *in situ*, the general nature of the construction, which was carried out with great diligence, can be inferred. He adds that the entire north and central part of the fort had collapsed, and there is only a gigantic heap of large stones. Guérin also mentions that the locals call these ruins Kharbet El-Kala'h and that referring to the two summits, Jebel Sartaba is also called Kournein Sarthabeh or Sarthabeh Bou-Kournein – Sartaba father of the two horns.

The members of the British Survey visited on 2 and 5 March, and 3 April, 1874 and described it thus: “Kurn Surtubeh (P p). – The ruins on the summit of this mountain consist of a central structure with surrounding wall...The top of the mountain is a cone, artificially shaped...and some 270 feet high. On all sides but the west this is practically unapproachable: on the west a trench has been cut, and the saddle thus made lower. The slope of the sides is about 35°. The top measures 90 feet east and west, and 258 feet north and south, being an oval. The foundation measures 92 feet 9 inches along a line 189°, and 40 feet 6 inches at right angles. There is a set-back on the south-west of 14 feet for 26 feet 9 inches. A wall runs south from this foundation for 18 feet, being 20 feet 6 inches across. The outer rampart, now merely a mound, is 30 feet across, and covered with fallen masonry, as is also the eastern slope of the hill. The foundation consists of 10 courses of masonry, the stones placed in alternate courses of headers and stretchers, and varying from 1.5 feet to 4 feet in length, the height of the course being 1 foot 10 inches. They have drafts from 3.5 to 6 inches broad, and the boss is left rustic, with a projection in some cases of 5 inches. Forty-four feet from the north end of the central foundation are two excavations or pits sunk in the soft rock, where are traces as if of the effects of fire kindled at some time in them. The building seems to have been struck by

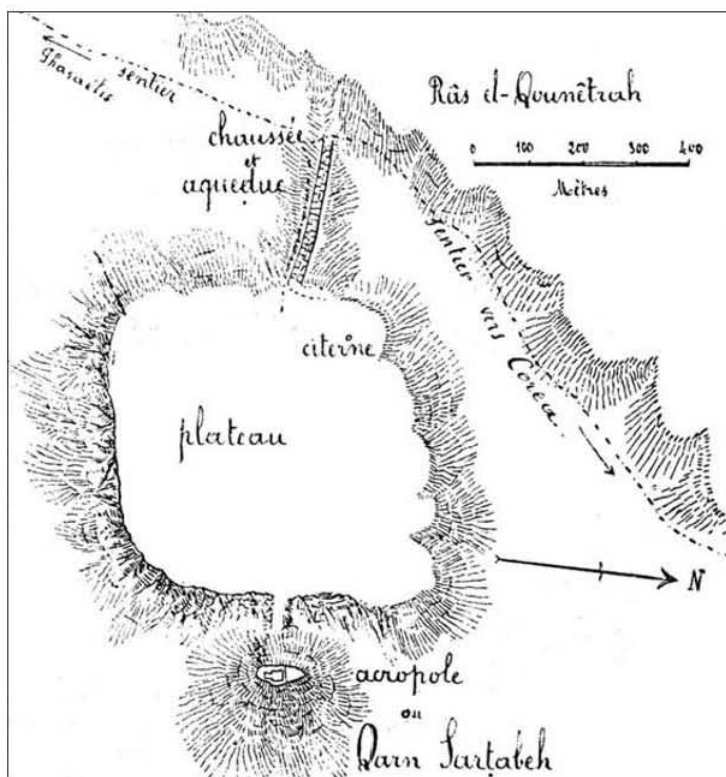
lightning, or perhaps shaken by earthquake, and the side of the tel on the east, for some 200 feet down, is strewn thickly with fallen ashlar, rather smaller than that of the foundation. The general appearance of the place is that of a fortress, with an oval outer *enceinte* and a central tower or keep, the foundations alone remaining. The masonry (which is of a hard crystalline limestone found on the ridge) is worked like that of the foundations at 'Athlit', and may possibly be Crusading. The mention of a castle here in the fourteenth century also favours this idea, as does the Arab tradition." (Conder and Kitchener 1882: 396-397).

Paul Sejourne (1895: 613-616), who visited the site in 1895, mentioned the rock-cut moat, the altitude on the cone and above the Rift Valley, the dimensions of the summit (80 paces in length and 25 in breadth), and he remarked that the construction should be related to the Roman era. He was so impressed by the view that he said that perhaps it was the most beautiful in the whole of the Land.

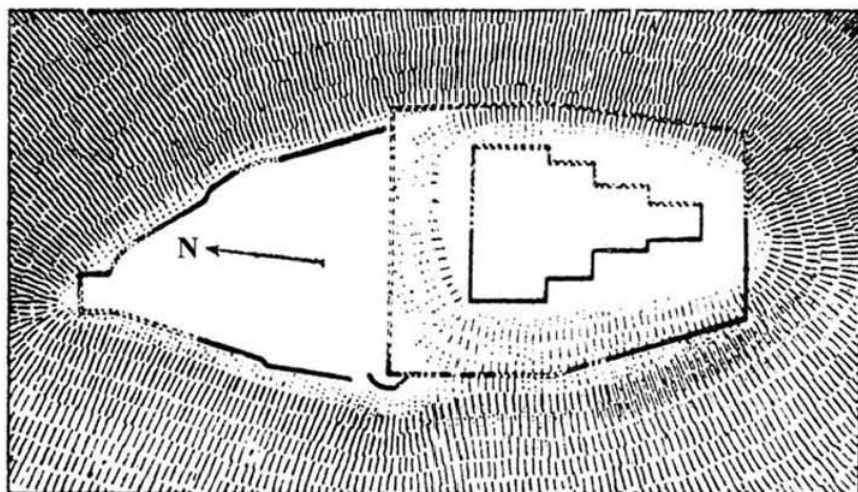
On 10 February 1910 Abel (1913: 227-234) visited the fortress. He mentioned the steep ascent to the Sartaba, the rhombus shape of the artificial summit, and its dimensions (100×40 m). He remarked that stones of the fortified wall in the southern part were worked either by smoothed cutting or coarse drafted margins with prominent bosses. He described the enclosure wall that surrounds the remains of the fortress, and he remarked on the dimensions of some of the stones – some are 1.06×0.47 m, others are 1.36×0.58 m, the boss protruded up to 0.06 m, and the width of the margins was 0.12 m. Abel also remarked that the Sartabah cone had been visited by a handful of researchers, and that Nathanael Schmidt's exploration in 1905 supplemented the British Survey work, resulting in the monograph 'Alexandrian' (Schmidt 1910). In a special article, Abel (1946) also tried to discover the location of the burial of Herod's sons.

On 10 October 1935 ten participants in an expedition of the American School of Oriental Research ascended the Sartaba, among them C.S. Fisher and W. F. Albright. Amongst their remarks should be noted the verification of identification of Alexandrian in the Sartaba (against the opinion of Robinson and Smith). Taking into account the state of the remains, the following remarks are significant:

1. "...we have a depression before the walls that may have been part of a small moat encircling this lofty stronghold. At first sight one might regard this simply as a hollow due to excavation, since it appears strange that the walls above, where cast down by earthquake, lightning, or the hands of men, should all have toppled in other directions. Elsewhere on the summit the debris effectually conceals whatever may be below." (Moulton 1936: 14).
2. All the pottery is from the 2nd century BCE to the 1st century CE (Moulton



335. Plan of the siphon, lower Sartaba and the Sartaba Fortress as measured by Abel in 1910 (Abel 1913: ill. 6).



336. A plan of the summit of the Sartaba Fortress as published by Abel (1913: ill. 7).

1936:18).

3. "As per the present fragment of wall, one notes a mingling of differing types of dressing, and also notes that some blocks have been dressed on the face, while in the case of others the process is incomplete. Such a blending of smooth and rough faces might belong to the period suggested before [Herodian, A. Z.], but it may be questioned whether the present fragment of wall comes from that time. Entirely apart from possible dislocations by lightening [sic], or by seismic disturbances, the joints are altogether too poor, and the reconstruction too slipshod to suit Herodian work. The present walls appear rather to be the careless and makeshift erection of some later day, possibly by Arabs. Much better work below ground would doubtless be brought to light by excavation." (Moulton 1936:18).

D. Excavations: between 1981 and 1984 Tsafir and Magen (1984;1993) conducted three seasons of excavations in a limited area in the east side of the site, below the summit. These excavations have not been published. Three building phases were noted during the excavations: 1. From the Hellenistic period (Hasmonean); 2. A Herodian peristyle hall; 3. A 1st century CE settlement.

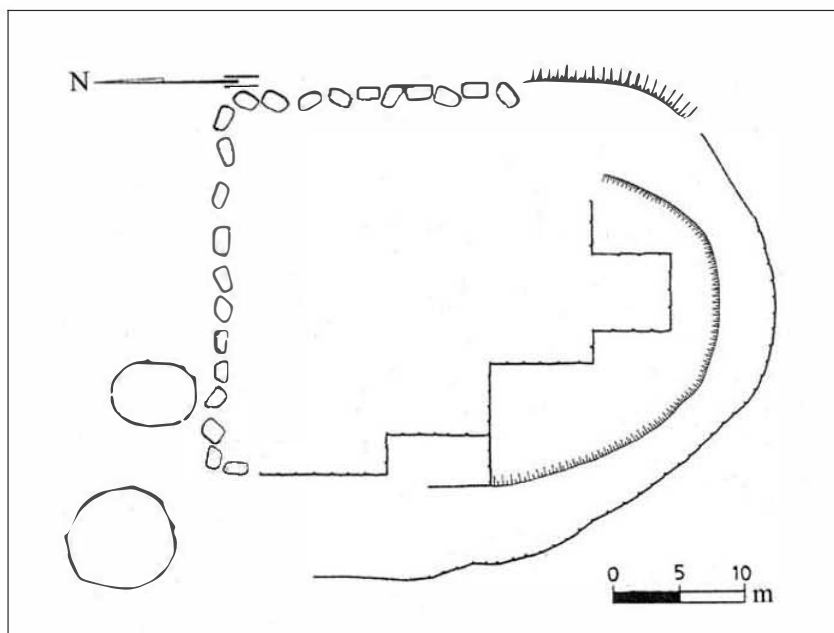
D1. Hasmonean building: beneath the Herodian peristyle were found Doric capitals and other parts of a splendid portico or facade. The excavators propose that the structure was destroyed by Gabinius in 57 BCE;

D2. Herodian peristyle: this is a square structure, the length of whose sides is 29.2 m, built on a step in the base rock plus fill. Aligned with the corners are four colonnades. The cross-section of the corner columns is heart-shaped. Coloured plaster has been preserved on some of the columns. At the centre of the hall were found remains of a mosaic floor. A cistern and a small pool were also exposed. The western wall is especially thick. There are similarities in style and methods of construction between the Herodian buildings at Masada and those of the peristyle in the Sartaba. Many sherds of the Eastern Sigillata type were found on the floor of the hall.

D3. The settlement in the 1st century CE: this settlement is attributed to the Roman garrison, and includes a baking stove and layers of ash over the preceding structures.

The small find includes coins, pottery, and storage jars, on some of which are inscriptions in Hebrew, Aramaic and Greek. Noteworthy are the names Pinhas Bar... (Pinhas son of...) and Levi Bar... (Levi son of...). The building was buried in a violent earthquake, which according to the excavators occurred 200–300 years after the abandonment.

E. New aspects: our Survey team visited the Sartaba on many occasions from



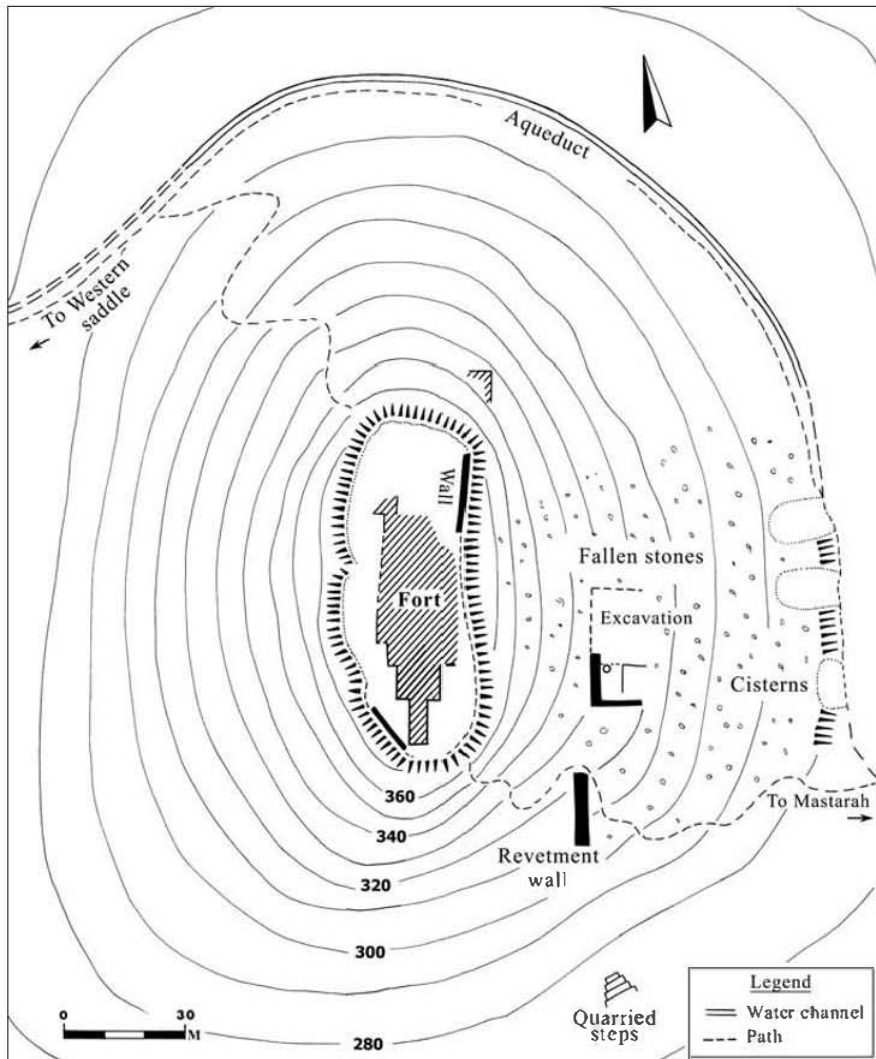
337. The plan of the Sartaba Fortress summit as published by the Emergency Survey (Bar-Adon 1972: 103).



338. The excavation area of the peristyle of Sartaba Fortress, showing the stone collapse from the structure on the summit. View to the west, 1998 (M. Einav).

1993 until recently. Two new plans have been drawn: that of the summit, and the entire mountain cone (in this entry). The bottom site on the western shoulder, the siege works and the water system have been explored (with a specific entry for each). An additional collection of sherds has also been made in the site, verifying the finds of this expedition and the previous ones. In addition to the above, IA pottery was also found.

Scrutinizing the upper citadel raises several issues. According to Abel's plan, which appears to be the most reliable and complete, the summit is divided into two: the northern half appears to be a levelled surface, while the citadel



339. Plan of the citadel and water system in the Sartaba Fortress, 1996.

stands on the southern half, which is 30x20 m and is a stepped structure. Such a form of a citadel is unknown in other sources in the Hellenistic era, and the roots of such an architectural design are unclear. We assume that a unique structure stood on the summit. The stone cutting practices do not conform, as already noted by Abel and Albright, to the acceptable standards of Herodian construction. Large-scale excavations are needed to address these issues.

Another issue is that of the excavations on both sides of the citadel. In various areas of the summit there are excavations whose nature is not clear. The first and deepest one is in the south-western part of the fortress. In this place the fill was removed to a depth of three to four courses, thus making a trench. This represents the original foundation trench in which the bottom courses of the citadel were laid. Therefore it could be concluded that these courses were built inside the trench which was then filled. This filling remained *in situ* in the more northern part, raising the questions of who removed it, and when. However, Abel and Albright considered it to be a moat, but this is not plausible. Other excavations were found to the east and alongside the first one, and also on the northern summit. Apparently these excavations already existed in 1870, during Guérin's visit.

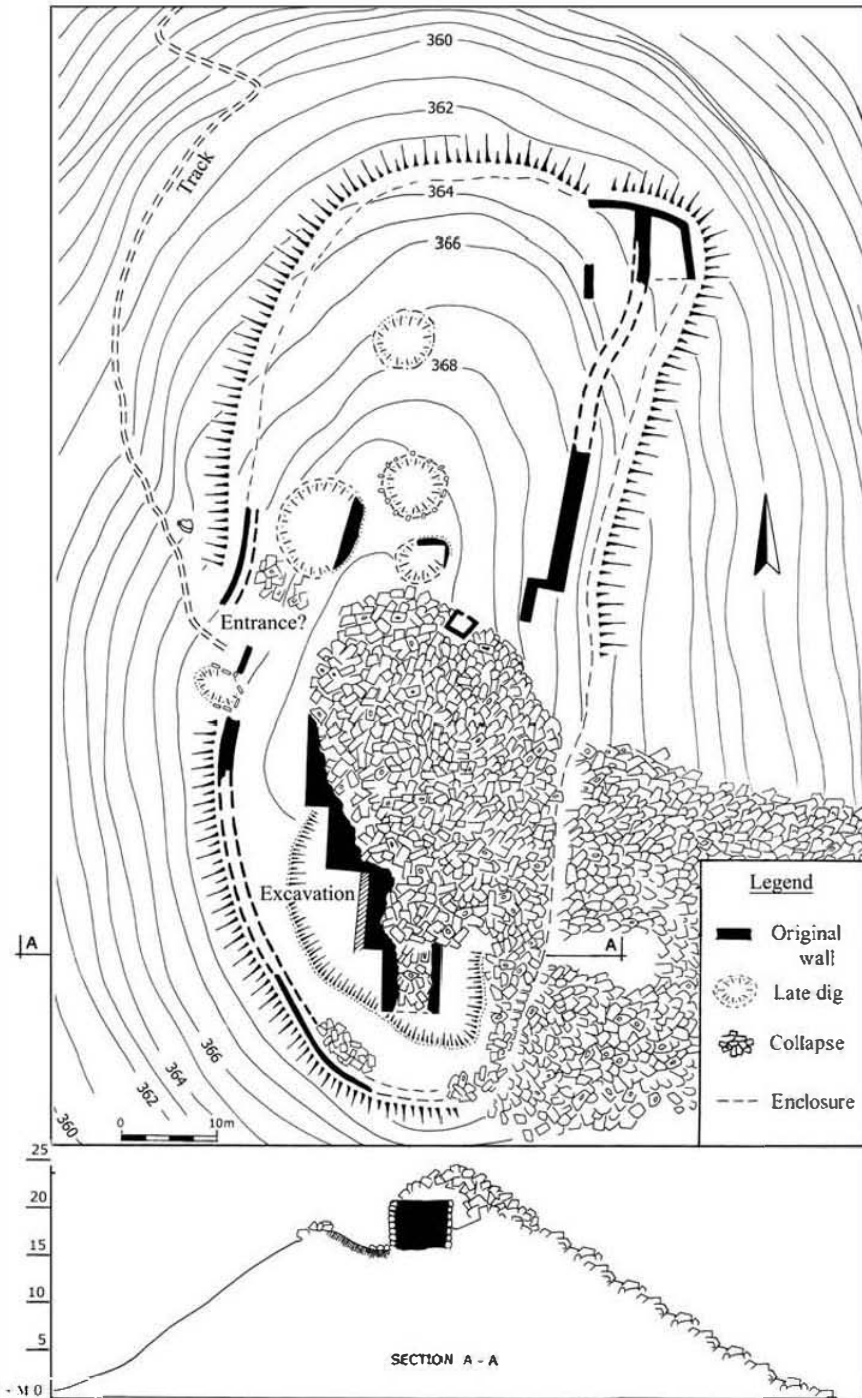
The newest issue concerning the site is the suggestion by Zertal that the Sartaba was actually a Herodian beacon. The function of the fortress (as is mentioned in the Mishnah), was kindling the beacons and spreading the news of the exact time of the appearance of the new moon from Jerusalem to the Jewish diaspora. For a complete presentation of this new idea see Zertal 2015.

Examining the location of the fortress in the area, our team has concluded that the citadel was but one element of a system, and the fortifications occupied almost the whole of the Sartaba plateau.

Pottery: Iron I-II – 2%; Hellenistic – 30%; Early Roman – 45%; Late Roman – 10%; Byzantine – 8%; Middle Ages – 5%.

Flint: 15 items, see Appendix A.

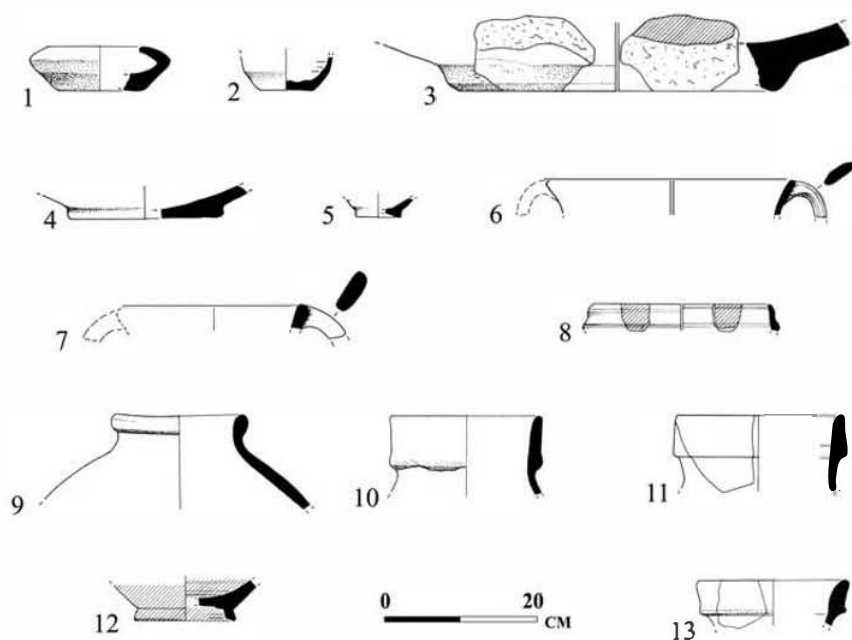
Additional Bibliography: Glueck 1951: site 253b; Porath 1968: site 168; Ilan 1973: 298-308; Tsafir 1975; Marcus 1992: 115-118; Guri-Rimon 1996: 17-18; Tsafir and Magen 1993 (with additional Bibliography); Meshel 2003; *NEAEHL* 5: 2110 (for additional Bibliography).



340. Detailed plan and cross-section of the summit of the Sartaba Fortress, 2002.
Note the excavation in the southern part and the robbing pits.



341. Aerial view to the east of the Sartaba plateau and the cone of the Sartaba Fortress, 1997 (M. Einav).



342. Pottery from the Sartaba Fortress: 1. Bowl, pk, Hel; 2. Base of juglet, buff, Hel; 3. Base of bowl, rd slip inside, Hel; 4. Base of bowl, rd, ER; 5. Base of juglet, buff, Hel; 6-7. CPs, brn, Rom.; 8. Bowl, buff with rd slip, ER; 9. Jar, buff, Hel; 10-11, 13. Jars, lt gr, Hel; 12. Base of juglet, rd slip, Hel.

Site 173 (1): 19-16/47/1

KHARBET KOUFA

Israel grid: 1941/1673

UTM grid: 7327/5543

Elevation: 244 m a.s.l., 200 m a.s.a.

Name: local

Site type: medium-sized

Area: 5 dunams (5000 sq. m)

Topography: ridge

Rock type: Judea Group

Soil type: stony-desert

Soil quality: 4

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: none

Water source: 'Ein Jeruzaliyeh (172),
1.3 km distantRoad: Mastarah-Sartaba (C44),
500 m distant

Visit: Dec. 2015; 150 sherds

A medium-sized site on the northern ridge of the Sartaba near E.P. 244, and 2.7 km south-west of Masua. From the site are extensive views, mainly eastwards, to the Jordan Valley and the Jordanian mountains.

The remains of thin walls were found at several locations at the site, but no clear remains of structures were noted. The main features found were a 30 m-long wall at the eastern part of the site that closes off the approach to the site from the east, and a robbed tumulus in the western part.

A large sherd scatter is visible.

The site was previously visited by several scholars. Guérin (1969: 244) ascended the Sartaba fortress on April 25, 1870, describing a site at the bottom of the mountain, which he called Kharbet Koufa. He located the site on the northern lower summit, and reported that all the area was covered with sherds and medium-sized stones originating from ruined buildings. He suggests that these are ancient quarries from which were cut the building stones which were used for the building of this village and the Sartaba.

Meshel described the siege system around the Sartaba (Meshel 1989), and suggested that this place was a military camp that he denoted as "Camp IX", and that the circumvallation reached the site from the north and the south-west on the very steep slopes of the ridge. His suggestion is mainly based on logical and topographical reasons, and we did not find circumvallation remains near the site or any finds to further support his idea.

Kharbet Koufa is a Hellenistic and ER site whose function and relationship with the Sartaba fort are still not clear.

Pottery: Hellenistic – 30%; Early Roman – 70%.

Additional surveys: Meshel 1989.

Additional Bibliography: Einav 2014.